(JCB) International, a Japanese national payment system; UnionPay, the Chinese equivalent; and others, despite ongoing sanctions.[97]

In 2015, China accelerated work on its own Cross-border Interbank Payment (i.e., not messaging) System (CIPS), given similar concerns about protecting its sovereignty from U.S. intelligence targeting of SWIFT.[98] China also has financial incentives to provide independent infrastructure in clearing and settlement services to facilitate use of the RMB in its growing cross-border trade and investment business. The number of domestic and foreign participants is increasing, and in March 2016, the institution managing CIPS contracted to connect with SWIFT's global user community, demonstrating again an interest in meeting market incentives while building parallel institutions. Eventually, current limitations with operating hours, liquidity, and connectivity are expected to be surmounted to help CIPS become a mainstream platform for RMB cross-border and offshore capital clearing and settlement.[99] In this sense, CIPS could be another outside option contributing to the gradual erosion of U.S. dollar dominance.

Finally, at the initiative of Moscow and Beijing, subsequently joined by Prime Minister Modi, the BRICS agreed at the Goa Summit to consider developing their own independent credit rating agency, building on the experience of nascent national agencies. Interest in this initiative reflects concerns that ratings agencies are subject to a range of conflicts of interest and that Western ratings firms are biased in favor of developed nations while pessimistic about developing and emerging economies, just as overly optimistic credit ratings contributed to the global financial crisis.[100]

In this case, then, the BRICS have hung together in resisting financial sanctions against Russia, while some members have also used outside options to reduce their future vulnerability to coercion by Washington and Brussels. At the same time, after Russian meddling in the 2016 election, the U.S. Congress voted overwhelmingly in 2017 to escalate the sanctions, codified them into law, and required Congressional approval to ease the penalties, making the sanctions regime extremely difficult for President Trump and future administrations to remove. This action, which significantly expands U.S. extraterritorial restrictions and breaks with the EU on pipelines and other Russian deals, demonstrates sustained U.S. leverage in financial statecraft. Intra-BRICS unity remains strong, but Russia's hope for an end to the sanctions appears more distant.